

Shashi Tharoor's Talk

A Well-Educated Mind vs. A Well-Formed Mind

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Introduction

In his talk “*A Well-Educated Mind vs. A Well-Formed Mind*”, Dr. Shashi Tharoor explores the urgent need for reform in India's higher education system. He begins with a reminder of India's most striking demographic feature—its **youthful population**. With 65% of citizens below the age of 35 and nearly half the population under 25, India is one of the youngest countries in the world. Around **226 million young people aged 10–19** are soon expected to enter higher education, placing immense pressure on the education system to perform. The **average age in India is only 28–29 years**, while countries like Japan, Europe, the US, and China have much older populations (above 40 years). This creates an opportunity for India to become the world's leading workforce.

However, Tharoor warns that this demographic advantage, known as the **demographic dividend**, can quickly turn into a **demographic disaster** if young people are not properly educated and skilled. An untrained, frustrated youth population may become vulnerable to unemployment, violence, extremism, and unrest. Therefore, education is not merely a **social or economic concern**, but also a critical **national security issue**.

The Four E's of Education

Tharoor frames the challenges of Indian education through what he calls the **Four E's: Expansion, Equity, Excellence, and Employability**.

1. **Expansion**

At the time of Independence in 1947, India was left with a literacy rate of only 16%. There were just 26 universities, fewer than 700 colleges, and only about 4 lakh students in higher education. Today, literacy has grown to 74%, and India now has around 650 universities, 35,000 colleges, and nearly 2 crore students

2. **Equity**

Historically, large groups of people were excluded from access to education, including women, lower castes, minority communities, and poorer regions. Female literacy at Independence was only 8.9%, meaning just 1 in 11 women could read and write. While inclusion has improved greatly, gaps and inequalities still remain.

3. **Excellence**

India boasts a handful of world-class institutions such as the IITs and IIMs. A symbolic example is **IIT Kharagpur**, established in 1956 by Jawaharlal Nehru on the site of the old Hijli Detention Camp once used by the British. What was once a symbol of political oppression was transformed into a center of hope and knowledge. Interestingly, Tharoor himself was born in the same year. Yet, beyond these prestigious institutes, the majority of India's universities are average or below average. This has led Tharoor to remark that India has “**islands of excellence floating in a sea of mediocrity**.”

4. **Employability**

One of the most serious concerns is the employability of graduates. Surveys by FICCI reveal that around **64% of employers are dissatisfied** with the quality of graduates entering the workforce. Even engineers, though highly educated, often require retraining. The IT giant Infosys, for instance, runs a massive training center in Mysore to re-educate fresh graduates before they can be put to work.

Government Efforts

To address these challenges, the Indian government has introduced several initiatives. The **Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009** made schooling free and compulsory for children between the ages of 6 and 14. Funding to state universities has increased, and **adult literacy programs** have been promoted to help older generations, particularly women. **Community colleges** have also been introduced to blend academics with vocational training, thereby equipping students with practical skills alongside classroom knowledge.

Literacy and Enrollment

Tharoor emphasizes that literacy is not just about reading words but about empowerment. He cites the example of **Chitra Mani from Tamil Nadu**, a woman who gained the confidence to travel independently after learning to read bus numbers and signs. Female literacy has improved significantly, rising from just 9% in 1947 to around 66% today. Yet the fact that one-third of Indian women remain illiterate is a sobering reminder of the work still ahead.

India's **Gross Enrollment Ratio (GER)** reveals both progress and challenges. At the primary level, enrollment is as high as 116% (since even older children enroll). However, the ratio drops steeply to 69% by class 8, 39% by class 10, and only 18% at the college level, compared to the global average of 29%. This reflects the widespread problem of **dropouts**, particularly after primary school.

Innovation and Thinking

While India is known for **jugaad** or frugal innovation—such as the Tata Nano, low-cost ECG machines, and affordable insulin injectors—true innovation requires original thinking and the creation of new ideas. Tharoor notes that ancient India contributed profoundly to world knowledge, with the invention of **zero at Nalanda** being a landmark achievement. Yet today, India contributes only 2.8% of global research output despite having 17% of the world's talent.

The problem, Tharoor explains, lies in an education system that focuses on filling minds with facts rather than shaping them to think. In the internet era, information is easily available, but what truly matters is a **well-formed mind**. Such a mind must be capable of responding to new information, thinking creatively, facing challenges beyond exams, and asking not only “*Why?*” but also “*Why not?*”

To illustrate this, Tharoor shares a personal anecdote: he frequently broke his eyeglasses, which were based on a century-old design. A friend solved this problem by redesigning spectacles with magnets at the bridge, making them far sturdier. This small example highlights the power of **out-of-the-box thinking**.

Conclusion

Shashi Tharoor concludes by emphasizing that India must simultaneously address **literacy, equity, excellence, employability, and innovation**. There is reason for optimism: today, about **95% of 12-year-olds in India can read and write**. If India can channel its demographic dividend wisely and provide its youth with meaningful education and skills, it can become the **workforce of the world**. Tharoor ends on a hopeful note, declaring, “*If we get all these pieces right, we can tell the world — we are coming.*”